PIA2050 Comparative Politics and Societies — Week 1 Summary: What is Comparative Politics?

1. Defining Comparative Politics

Keywords: subfield, Political Science, domestic politics, Siaroff, actors, institutions, processes

1.1 The Textbook Definition (Slide 2)

Keywords: main subfield, internal politics, any country, Siaroff 2022

- Comparative Politics is one of the **main subfields** of the social-scientific discipline known as **Political Science** (Slide 2).
- Siaroff 2022 (pp. 1–2): Comparative Politics is a field that focuses on the internal or domestic politics of any country in the world.
- Two elements to retain (memorise):
    - **Internal/domestic** — what happens *inside* states, as opposed to relations *between* states (the domain of International Relations, Section 3).
    - **Any country** — no country is excluded in principle; rich or poor, democratic or not, large or small.
- One-liner: *Comparative Politics = the study of politics inside countries, any countries.*

1.2 The Three Objects of Study (Slide 2)

Keywords: political actors, political institutions, political processes, leaders, regimes, elections

More precisely, the field studies three kinds of things (Slide 2):

- **Political actors** — the people and groups who act politically.
    - *Example:* leaders, elites, voters.
- **Political institutions** — the rules and structures within which actors operate.
    - *Example:* regimes, legislatures, federalism.
- **Political processes** — the dynamic events and sequences through which politics unfolds.
    - *Example:* elections, social movements.

- → Easy mnemonic: **who** acts (actors), **within what rules** (institutions), **through what events** (processes).
- → The three are interlinked: institutions shape how actors behave; processes (e.g. elections) are where actors and institutions meet. This course concentrates on **institutions and regimes** and their effect on actors (Sections 9–10).

2. Description and Explanation (Slide 3)

Keywords: comparativists, evidence, observation, descriptive, explanatory, theory-testing, variation

- Comparativists are scholars who use evidence/observation to study political actors, institutions and processes (Slide 3).
- They do so in **two senses**, which together define the field's purpose.

2.1 The Descriptive Sense

Keywords: differences, similarities, political systems, classification

- Descriptive comparison — describing differences and similarities across various political systems (Slide 3).
- Answers *"what is the case?"* questions.
    - *Example:* Which countries use proportional representation and which use single-member districts? Which regimes hold competitive elections?
- → Description is the necessary first step: you cannot explain a difference you have not first accurately identified.

2.2 The Explanatory Sense

Keywords: theory, causes, consequences, outcomes, variation across time and space

- Explanatory comparison — developing and testing theories that study the causes and consequences of particular outcomes or phenomena, or their variation across time and space (Slide 3).
- Answers *"why?"* and *"with what effect?"* questions.
- Three kinds of explanatory target:
    - **Causes** of an outcome — *Example:* why do some countries become democracies?
    - **Consequences** of an outcome — *Example:* does the type of electoral system affect political stability?
    - **Variation** — across **space** (between countries) or across **time** (within one country at different moments).
- → The modern field is defined by the move from *mainly descriptive* to *explanatory, theory-driven* work (Sections 7–8).

- One-liner: *Description tells you that countries differ; explanation tells you why they differ and what difference it makes.*

3. Comparative Politics among the Subfields of Political Science (Slides 3–4)

Keywords: three or four subfields, Political Theory, International Relations, American Politics, disciplinary convention

3.1 The Main Subfields (Slides 3–4)

Keywords: political philosophy, international relations, American politics, counting subfields

- Depending on how they are counted, Comparative Politics is **one of three or four main subfields** of Political Science (Slide 3).
- It is distinguished from (Slide 4):

1. **Political Theory** — more accurately **political philosophy** (normative questions such as justice, legitimacy, rights).
2. **International Relations** — politics *between* states and in the international system.
3. **American Politics** — the lecturer's "(huh?)" flags how odd this distinction is.

- → Comparative Politics vs International Relations: **inside** countries vs **between** countries.
- → Comparative Politics vs Political Theory: **empirical** (evidence-based description and explanation) vs **philosophical/normative**.

3.2 The "American Politics" Puzzle (Slide 4)

Keywords: domestic politics of a single nation, volume of research, substantive difference, subsumed

- Question posed: what is the difference between Comparative Politics and **American Politics** (or French, Korean politics, etc.), *aside from the volume of research published on the subject*? (Slide 4)
- Answer (Slide 4): **substantively, none**.
- The study of the domestic politics of **any** nation can be **subsumed** under the heading of Comparative Politics.
- → American Politics is a separate subfield only for **institutional/historical reasons** (the size of the US discipline and the amount of research on the US), not because it studies something different in kind.
- *Example:* a study of US congressional elections and a study of Korean National Assembly elections examine the same class of phenomenon — legislative elections.

4. A Field Defined by a Method: Sartori (Slides 5–6)

Keywords: Sartori 1991, comparative method, to compare is to control, generalisation, validity

4.1 Not Every Single-Country Study Qualifies (Slide 5)

Keywords: really comparative, counter-argument, method not subject matter

- Counter-argument to Section 3.2: **not every study of the domestic politics of a country qualifies as Comparative Politics** — it depends on whether the research is **really comparative** (Slide 5).
- So the field may be defined not by **what** it studies (domestic politics) but by **how** it studies it.

4.2 "A Field Defined by a Method" (Slide 5)

Keywords: Giovanni Sartori, comparative method, methodological identity

- Political scientist Giovanni Sartori 1991 called Comparative Politics "a field defined by a method" (Slide 5).
- The method: the comparative method (Slide 5).
- → Contrast the two definitions (memorise):
    - **Substantive definition** (Siaroff 2022): the field = domestic politics of any country.
    - **Methodological definition** (Sartori 1991): the field = research that actually *compares*.

4.3 "To Compare Is to Control" (Slides 5–6)

Keywords: control, valid generalisations, individual countries, why compare

- Sartori added: "to compare is to control" (Slide 5).
- Control **what**? Control that **generalisations made on the basis of individual countries are valid** (Slide 5).
- Slide 6 ("Why compare?") quotes Sartori 1991 (pp. 244–5) on this point.
- Standard logic behind the claim:
    - Political scientists usually **cannot run experiments** (no one can randomly assign a country a new electoral system or a revolution).
    - Comparison across cases is the substitute: a claim that holds in one country is **checked** against other countries to see whether it holds, fails, or needs conditions attached.
- *Example:* if a study of one country concludes "economic crisis causes democratic breakdown", comparison asks whether other countries hit by crisis also broke down — if many did not, the generalisation is invalid or incomplete.

- → Comparison is the **check on overgeneralisation**: without it, a finding from one case is just a description of that case.
- One-liner: *Comparing = testing whether what is true here is also true there.*

5. Single-Country Studies (Slide 7)

Keywords: implicitly comparative, general literature, theory application, events vs classes of events

5.1 When Do Single-Country Studies Count? (Slide 7)

Keywords: implicitly comparative, bring theory to the case, inform the literature

- Question: can a study of a **single country** count as Comparative Politics, given Sartori's view? (Slide 7)
- Common answer: **yes**, as long as it is "implicitly comparative" — it brings theories and findings developed by the general literature to bear on the case at hand, and/or reflects on how the case might inform the general literature (Slide 7).
- Two directions (memorise):
    - **Literature → case:** use general theories to explain the country.
    - **Case → literature:** use the country to confirm, refine or challenge general theories.
- *Example:* Ferrara 2015, *The Political Development of Modern Thailand* (in the reference list, Slide 18), is a single-country study; it counts as Comparative Politics to the extent that it engages with general theories of political development and speaks back to them.
- → What disqualifies a single-country study is not the number of cases but **isolation from general theory**.

5.2 Historians vs Comparativists (Slide 7)

Keywords: events, classes of events, generalisation, caveat

- Common claim: historians are interested in events, while comparativists focus on classes of events (Slide 7).
    - *Example:* a historian studies *the* French Revolution of 1789; a comparativist studies *revolutions* as a category, with 1789 as one instance.
- Caveat on the slide: **"that's not always true"** — historians also generalise, and comparativists sometimes study single events in depth.
- → Treat the distinction as a **tendency**, not a strict boundary.

6. The "Big Questions": Lichbach and Zuckerman (Slide 8)

Keywords: Lichbach and Zuckerman 1997, ambitious scope, intellectual visions, big questions of social thought

Lichbach and Zuckerman 1997 describe Comparative Politics through **three characteristics** (Slide 8) (memorise all three).

6.1 Ambitious Scope of Inquiry

Keywords: no phenomenon foreign, all levels of analysis, all time periods

- No political phenomenon is foreign to it, no level of analysis is irrelevant to it, no time period is beyond its reach (Slide 8).
- Three dimensions of scope:
    - **Phenomena** — from voting to revolutions to state formation.
    - **Levels of analysis** — individuals, groups, institutions, whole states.
    - **Time** — from early state formation to the present.

6.2 Ambitious Intellectual Visions

Keywords: general questions, cases not for their own sake

- Practitioners approach events and cases with general questions in mind, not for their own sake (Slide 8).
- → Links directly to Section 5: a case matters because of what it tells us about a **general question**.

6.3 Concern for the Big Questions of Social Thought

Keywords: social theory, enduring questions, wealth, power, order

- The field addresses the **"big questions" of social thought** (Slide 8).
- *Example:* why are some nations rich and others poor; why are some countries democratic and others not — both are themes of this course (Section 10).
- → The course's own list of big questions (Slides 14–17) follows this tradition.

7. Teaching Approach 1: Country-Based (Slides 9–10)

Keywords: country-by-country, rich/poor, democratic/non-democratic, descriptive, legalistic, configurative

7.1 What the Country-Based Approach Is (Slide 9)

Keywords: select countries, structure and workings, political systems

- There are **at least two ways** to teach Comparative Politics (Slide 9).
- Country-based approach: choose a few countries (rich/poor, democratic/non-democratic, or whatever) and focus on the structure and workings of their political systems (Slide 9).
- Slide 10 shows an example of a country-based textbook; the reference list's Kesselman, Krieger and Joseph 2019, *Introduction to Comparative Politics* (8th ed.), follows this format.

7.2 What It Reflects (Slide 9)

Keywords: old field, descriptive, legalistic, configurative, formal vs real politics

- This approach reflects **what Comparative Politics once was** (Slide 9):
    - **Descriptive** — describing institutions rather than explaining outcomes.
    - **Legalistic** — focused on constitutions and laws.
    - **Configurative** — describing each country's overall configuration of institutions one at a time.
- The field later became (Slide 9):
    - more **explanatory**,
    - **theoretically informed**,
    - **methodologically conscious**,
    - focused on **real** (as opposed to **formal**) politics.
- → **Formal politics** = what the rules say; **real politics** = how power actually works in practice.
- *Example:* a constitution may describe an elected parliament as supreme, while in practice the military or a ruling party holds real power — a purely legalistic study would miss this.

8. The Field's Past and Present (Slides 11–12)

Keywords: legal structures, 1950s turn, causal explanation, behavioural revolution, Cold War, statistics, game theory

8.1 The Field's Past: Comparing Legal Structures (Slide 11)

Keywords: descriptive comparison, domestic legal structures, formal-legal

- **Initially**, Comparative Politics was preoccupied with the **descriptive** comparison of different countries' **domestic legal structures** (Slide 11).
- This is often called the formal-legal approach (constitutions, laws, offices).

8.2 The 1950s Turn (Slide 11)

Keywords: explanatory, causal, less formal, laws incomplete story, sophistication

- In the **1950s**, the field adopted a more **explanatory (causal)**, less **formal/legalistic** focus (Slide 11).
- Basis: recognition that a nation's laws do NOT tell us anywhere close to the complete story of how politics works in that nation (Slide 11).
- Comparativists also sought and acquired greater **theoretical and methodological sophistication** (Slide 11).

- → Shift in one line: from **"what do the laws say?"** to **"what actually happens, and why?"**

8.3 Reason 1: The Behavioural Revolution (Slide 12)

Keywords: behaviouralism, real/informal politics, game theory, statistical methods, technology

- Behavioural revolution in the social sciences (Slide 12): a move to study **observable political behaviour** (how people actually act) rather than formal rules.
- It coincided with (Slide 12):
    - greater interest in **real/informal politics**;
    - greater popularity of game theory (modelling strategic interaction between actors) and **statistical methods**;
    - **technological advances** that made statistical analysis more accessible to scholars and students.
- *Example:* survey research on why voters choose particular parties, analysed statistically, replaces a description of what the electoral law says.

8.4 Reason 2: Geopolitical Context (Slide 12)

Keywords: Cold War, USSR, communism, Hitler, World War II, American determination

- **Changes in geopolitical context** (Slide 12), especially:
    - the **American determination to win the Cold War** against the **USSR/communism** — this required understanding politics in many countries, not only Western democracies;
    - the desire to understand the **causes of Hitler's rise and World War II** — a constitutional democracy (Weimar Germany) collapsed into dictatorship, showing that formal rules alone do not explain outcomes.
- → Both pressures pushed the field toward **causal** questions: why do democracies collapse; why do countries go communist; what makes regimes stable?
- One-liner: *Method (behaviouralism, statistics, game theory) plus politics (Cold War, WWII) turned a descriptive legal field into an explanatory science.* (memorise both reasons)

9. Teaching Approach 2: Thematic (Slides 13–14)

Keywords: thematic, problem-based, general topics, evidence from many countries, political institutions

9.1 What the Thematic Approach Is (Slide 13)

Keywords: problem-based, aspects of politics, descriptive and explanatory questions, variety of cases

- Thematic approach (or **problem-based** approach): instead of proceeding country by country, select particular aspects of politics and society and ask important questions, both descriptive and explanatory, to be answered through evidence gleaned from a variety of countries/cases (Slide 13).
- The key question changes (Slide 13):
    - **Not** "which countries should we cover?"
    - **But** "which general topics or themes should we include or exclude?"
- *Example:* Siaroff 2022's textbook is subtitled *A Thematic Introduction to Comparative Politics* (Slide 18).

9.2 This Course's Focus (Slides 13–14)

Keywords: political institutions, development over time, effects on behaviour, interactions

- The lecturer's courses generally focus on **political institutions** (Slide 13):
    - their **development over time**;
    - their **effect on the behaviour** of relevant actors and their **interactions**.
- Ferrara 2022, *The Development of Political Institutions: Power, Legitimacy, Democracy* (Slide 18), matches this focus.
- Slide 14 presents the course's **"big questions"**, taken from the course outline; Slides 15–17 set them out theme by theme (Section 10).

10. The Course's Themes and Big Questions (Slides 15–17)

Keywords: political institutions, regimes, traditions of inquiry, political development, state formation, democracy, institutional design, wealth of nations

- The course focuses mostly on themes related to **political institutions and regimes** (Slide 15).
- Regimes are configurations of institutions determining the manner in which a country is governed (Slide 15).
- Eight themes follow (the two economic themes are combined in 10.7); each comes with guiding questions (memorise the theme names).

10.1 Traditions of Inquiry in Comparative Politics (Slide 15)

Keywords: how to study, purpose of comparison, drivers of political behaviour

- How should we study the domestic politics of **one or more** countries?
- What are comparisons **for**, really? (Links to Sartori, Section 4.)
- What **motivates/drives** political behaviour?

10.2 Political Development (Slide 15)

Keywords: engine of history, institutional development over time

- What is **"the engine" of history**?
- How do political institutions **develop over time**?

10.3 State Formation and Nation-Building (Slide 16)

Keywords: nation-states, failed states

- Why do we live in a world of **"nation-states"**?
- What causes **"failed states"**?

10.4 Democracy and Non-Democracy (Slide 16)

Keywords: regime types, classifying democracy, varieties of non-democratic regimes

- What are the world's **most common regimes**?
- How can we tell if a country is a **"democracy"** or not?
- What are the major **varieties of non-democratic regimes**?
- → A **descriptive/classification** theme (Section 2.1).

10.5 Democratic Transitions and Authoritarian Reversals (Slide 16)

Keywords: causes of democracy, democratisation, democratic instability, collapse

- Why are some countries democratic, while others are ruled by **non-democratic regimes**?
- How do countries **become** democratic?
- What makes democracy **unstable** or at risk of **collapse**?
- → An **explanatory** theme (Section 2.2); connects to the field's founding interest in Hitler's rise (Section 8.4).

10.6 Designing Political Institutions (Slide 17)

Keywords: form of government, electoral system, federalism, institutional engineering

- How do political institutions — **form of government, electoral system, federalism** — affect a country's **political life, stability and prosperity**?
- Can desirable outcomes be **"engineered"** through the design of institutions? (institutional engineering)
- *Example:* choosing between presidential and parliamentary government, or between proportional and majoritarian electoral rules, in a new constitution.

10.7 The Wealth of Nations, and Economic Development and Prosperity (Slide 17)

Keywords: rich and poor countries, inequality between and within countries, politics and growth

- **The wealth of nations:**

    - Why are some regions/countries **rich**, and others **poor**?
    - What accounts for the **extreme inequality** commonly observed **between** countries and **within** countries?

- **Economic development and prosperity:**

    - How does a country's **politics** affect its levels of **economic growth and development**?

- → These are "big questions of social thought" in the Lichbach and Zuckerman 1997 sense (Section 6.3).

11. One-Page Revision Spine

Keywords: last-minute recap, definitions, Sartori, history of the field, course themes

4. **Definition (Slide 2):** Siaroff 2022 — Comparative Politics is a main subfield of Political Science studying the **internal/domestic politics of any country**: **actors** (leaders, elites, voters), **institutions** (regimes, legislatures, federalism), **processes** (elections, social movements).
5. **Two senses (Slide 3): descriptive** (differences and similarities across political systems) and **explanatory** (theories of causes, consequences and variation across time/space).
6. **Subfields (Slides 3–4):** one of three or four — vs **Political Theory** (political philosophy), **International Relations**, **American Politics**. Comparative vs American Politics: **substantively no difference**; all domestic politics can be subsumed under Comparative Politics.
7. **Method definition (Slide 5):** Sartori 1991 — "a field defined by a method", the comparative method; **"to compare is to control"** = control that generalisations drawn from individual countries are **valid** (Slide 6: "Why compare?").
8. **Single-country studies (Slide 7):** count if **implicitly comparative** — theory → case and/or case → theory. Historians study **events**, comparativists **classes of events** — but not always.
9. **Big questions (Slide 8):** Lichbach and Zuckerman 1997 — **ambitious scope** (no phenomenon, level or period excluded), **ambitious intellectual visions** (general questions, not cases for their own sake), **big questions of social thought**.
10. **Country-based approach (Slides 9–10):** a few countries, structure and workings of their systems; reflects the old field — **descriptive, legalistic, configurative**; e.g. Kesselman, Krieger and Joseph 2019.
11. **Field's past (Slide 11):** descriptive comparison of **legal structures** → **1950s** turn to **explanatory/causal**, less legalistic work, because **laws do not tell the complete story**; plus theoretical/methodological sophistication.
12. **Why the switch (Slide 12):** (i) Behavioural revolution — real/informal politics, game theory, statistics, technology making analysis accessible; (ii) **geopolitics** — winning the **Cold War** against the USSR/communism; understanding **Hitler's rise and WWII**.

13. **Thematic approach (Slide 13):** select aspects of politics/society, ask descriptive and explanatory questions, answer with evidence from many cases — "which **themes**", not "which **countries**". Course focus: **political institutions**, their development and effects on actors.
14. **Course themes (Slides 14–17):** regimes = configurations of institutions determining the manner in which a country is governed; themes: traditions of inquiry; political development; state formation and nation-building; democracy and non-democracy; democratic transitions/authoritarian reversals; designing political institutions; the wealth of nations; economic development and prosperity.
15. **References (Slide 18):** Siaroff 2022 (definition, thematic), Sartori 1991 (method, control), Kesselman, Krieger and Joseph 2019 (country-based), Ferrara 2015 (single-country, Thailand), Ferrara 2022 (development of political institutions).